

MONTESSORI NAVIGATOR™

New Family Onboarding Playbook

A 90-Day Guided Journey for Families New to Montessori

EXAMPLE PLAYBOOK

Willow Creek Montessori School

Serving children ages 18 months through 12 years

Purpose of This Playbook

This playbook is designed to guide your school through a thoughtful, structured 90-day onboarding experience for every new family that enrolls. The goal is not simply to transfer information, but to build understanding, trust, and partnership between home and school.

Montessori education works best when families and schools share a common language, common expectations, and mutual respect for the developmental process. Many of the misunderstandings that arise in the first year of enrollment can be traced back to the onboarding period, specifically to gaps in communication, unclear expectations, or missed opportunities to build connection.

This playbook addresses those gaps head-on with a phased approach that moves families from logistical readiness through philosophical understanding and into active partnership.

Who This Playbook Is For

This playbook is designed for school administrators, enrollment coordinators, and heads of school. It provides a complete, ready-to-implement onboarding system. If your school uses Montessori Growth Suite, this entire sequence can be imported as an automated workflow.

The Onboarding Philosophy

In a Montessori classroom, the environment is carefully prepared before the child arrives. Materials are placed intentionally, the space is arranged to promote independence, and the guide has anticipated needs before they arise. New family onboarding should reflect the same principle.

When we prepare the environment for incoming families, we are doing several things simultaneously: reducing anxiety by providing clear information in manageable doses, building philosophical alignment so families understand why the school operates the way it does, establishing communication norms so families know what to expect and how to engage, and creating early touchpoints that build trust and connection with the school community.

The 90-day framework is structured into three distinct phases, each with its own goals and emotional texture.

Phase 1: Welcome and Prepare (Enrollment to First Day)

This phase focuses on logistics, expectations, and excitement. Families need to feel organized, informed, and warmly received. They need to know what to bring, what to expect, and that they have chosen well. Emails in this phase are warm, practical, and confidence-building.

Phase 2: Settle and Understand (Days 1–30)

This phase focuses on the adjustment period. Children are adapting to a new environment, and parents are often anxious, curious, or second-guessing. Emails in this phase normalize the transition, explain what the child is experiencing, and give parents specific language and tools for supporting the process at home.

Phase 3: Deepen and Partner (Days 30–90)

This phase shifts from support to education. Families are now settled enough to engage with deeper Montessori concepts. Emails in this phase introduce developmental philosophy, explain classroom practices, and invite families into the broader school community. The goal is to move families from passive consumers of a service to active partners in their child's education.

Age-Level Considerations

While the core onboarding structure applies across all age levels, the specific content shared with families should be adapted. An infant/toddler family needs guidance on separation, sleep, and toileting awareness. A primary family needs help understanding the three-year cycle and the role of the guide. An elementary family needs context on the Great Lessons, the going out program, and increasing independence. This playbook includes age-specific content suggestions for each email.

90-Day Onboarding Timeline

The following timeline provides an overview of all touchpoints, emails, and actions across the full onboarding period. Each item is assigned a responsible party and recommended timing.

TIMING	ACTION	OWNER
Day 0	Email 1: Welcome to the Family (sent on enrollment)	Automated
Day 2	Email 2: What to Expect on the First Day	Automated
Day 5	Email 3: Understanding the Montessori Classroom	Automated
Week 1	Personal phone call or video welcome from Head of School	Head of School
Pre-Start	Email 4: Preparing Your Child (and Yourself)	Automated
Day 1	First day of school — guide sends brief personal note	Lead Guide
Day 3	Email 5: The First Week — What You Might Notice	Automated
Day 7	Email 6: Why Montessori Looks Different (and Why That's Good)	Automated
Day 14	Email 7: Building Independence at Home	Automated
Week 3	Parent observation opportunity (in-classroom)	Enrollment Coord.
Day 21	Email 8: Understanding Your Child's Development	Automated
Day 30	Email 9: Your First Month — A Reflection	Automated
Day 45	Informal check-in from guide or admin	Lead Guide
Day 60	Email 10: Becoming a Montessori Family	Automated
Day 75	Invitation to parent education event or community gathering	Enrollment Coord.
Day 90	Formal welcome as full community member	Head of School

The Email Sequence

Below are the ten emails that form the backbone of the onboarding experience. Each email is written in full, ready to send or adapt. Subject lines, timing, and age-level variations are included.

Email 1: Welcome to the Family

Trigger: Sent immediately upon enrollment confirmation

EMAIL | Sent immediately upon enrollment

Subject: Welcome to Willow Creek Montessori — We're So Glad You're Here

Dear [Parent First Name],

We are delighted to welcome your family to Willow Creek Montessori. Enrolling your child is one of the most meaningful decisions you can make as a parent, and we are honored that you have chosen to make this journey with us.

Over the next few weeks, we will be sending you a series of emails designed to help you and your child prepare for this new chapter. These are not overwhelming checklists or lengthy policy documents. They are thoughtful, manageable guides meant to build your confidence and help you feel at home.

Here is what you can expect:

In the next email, we will walk you through exactly what the first day looks like, including arrival, separation, and what your child will experience. After that, we will share insights into the Montessori classroom itself, so you understand the environment your child will be entering. And before the first day arrives, we will help you prepare both practically and emotionally.

In the meantime, please do not hesitate to reach out if you have any questions. Our enrollment coordinator, [Enrollment Coordinator Name], is available at [email] or [phone] and would love to hear from you.

Welcome to our community. We are so glad you are here.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Age-Level Variations

For infant/toddler families, add a line about the upcoming separation process and that the school will work closely with them on transition. For elementary families, mention the exciting intellectual journey ahead and that the classroom community will welcome their child warmly.

Email 2: What to Expect on the First Day

Trigger: 2 days after Email 1

EMAIL | Day 2 after enrollment

Subject: What the First Day Actually Looks Like

Dear [Parent First Name],

The first day at a new school can feel big for everyone involved, children and parents alike. We want to walk you through exactly what to expect so there are no surprises.

Arrival

School doors open at [time]. You will bring your child to the [location, e.g., front entrance or classroom door], where their guide, [Guide Name], will greet them personally. We recommend a warm, brief goodbye. Children take their cues from us, and a confident, loving send-off sets a positive tone.

The Morning

Your child will be gently introduced to the classroom environment. In Montessori, we do not expect children to sit and listen on day one. Instead, your child's guide will offer them a few carefully chosen activities and allow them to begin exploring at their own pace. Some children dive right in; others prefer to observe first. Both are perfectly normal and perfectly welcome.

Pickup

At [pickup time], you will collect your child from [location]. Their guide or a member of our team will be available to share a brief update on how the day went.

What to Bring

Please send your child with: a labeled water bottle, a change of clothes in a labeled bag, [any age-specific items, e.g., diapers for toddlers, a packed lunch for full-day students]. Please avoid sending toys, character clothing, or items that might distract from the work environment.

You are going to do great, and so is your child.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Email 3: Understanding the Montessori Classroom

Trigger: 5 days after enrollment

EMAIL | Day 5 after enrollment

Subject: Inside the Montessori Classroom — What Makes It Different

Dear [Parent First Name],

If you have visited our classrooms, you may have noticed that they look quite different from what most of us experienced growing up. That is by design.

A Montessori classroom is what we call a prepared environment. Every material, every piece of furniture, and every element of the daily routine has been thoughtfully arranged to support your child's natural development. Here are a few things that might stand out:

Mixed ages. Your child will be in a classroom with children spanning a three-year age range. This is one of the most powerful elements of Montessori. Younger children learn by observing older peers, and older children deepen their understanding by mentoring younger ones. It mirrors the way humans have always learned in families and communities.

Freedom within structure. Children choose their own work throughout much of the day. This is not a free-for-all. It is a carefully structured freedom, guided by the teacher (whom we call a guide), where children learn to make decisions, manage their time, and follow their curiosity. The guide observes each child closely and offers lessons and invitations based on readiness.

Hands-on materials. Instead of worksheets and textbooks, children work with beautifully designed hands-on materials that make abstract concepts concrete. Your child will literally hold mathematical concepts in their hands before they ever write an equation.

Long, uninterrupted work periods. The morning work cycle typically runs for three uninterrupted hours. This allows children to enter states of deep concentration, which Maria Montessori identified as essential to healthy development. You will not see constant transitions or frequent interruptions.

In our next email, we will help you and your child prepare emotionally and practically for the first day. In the meantime, if you would like to learn more, the Montessori Foundation's Montessori Navigator platform has excellent resources for parents.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Email 4: Preparing Your Child (and Yourself)

Trigger: 3–5 days before the child’s first day

EMAIL | 3–5 days before first day

Subject: Getting Ready — Practical Tips for the Days Ahead

Dear [Parent First Name],

Your child’s first day is almost here. Here are some simple, practical things you can do in the next few days to set everyone up for success.

For Your Child

Talk about school positively but matter-of-factly. You might say something like, “You’re going to a place where children get to choose their own work and learn new things. Your guide’s name is [Guide Name].” Avoid over-preparing or making it sound like a huge event, which can increase anxiety.

Practice the goodbye routine. If your child is not accustomed to being dropped off, practice a brief, loving goodbye at home. A short ritual, such as a special handshake, a kiss on the hand, or a simple “I love you and I’ll be back after lunch,” gives children something predictable to hold onto.

Encourage independence at home. Let your child dress themselves (even if it takes longer), pour their own water, and carry their own bag. These small acts of independence build the confidence they will draw on in the classroom.

For Yourself

It is completely normal to feel a mix of excitement and anxiety. Many parents find the first few days harder than their child does. Trust that your child is in a carefully prepared environment with trained, attentive guides who have supported hundreds of families through this transition.

Resist the urge to ask “What did you do today?” right at pickup. Children often need time to decompress. Instead, try specific, open-ended observations: “You look like you had a good day.” or “I noticed your hands are a little messy — it looks like you were working hard.”

We are ready for you, and we cannot wait to welcome your child.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Toddler-Specific Addition

For families with children under 3, include additional guidance on the phase-in schedule: “Your child will attend for a shorter day during the first week as they build comfort with the environment. Your guide will communicate daily about readiness for extending the day. This is not a sign of difficulty — it is a sign of respect for your child’s pace.”

Email 5: The First Week — What You Might Notice

Trigger: 3 days after the child's first day

EMAIL | Day 3 of attendance

Subject: The First Week — What's Normal (and What to Expect at Home)

Dear [Parent First Name],

Now that your child has been at Willow Creek for a few days, you may be noticing some things at home. Here is what is completely normal during the first week and beyond.

Your child might be tired. A Montessori classroom engages children at a deep level — cognitively, physically, and socially. Even if your child “just played,” they have been working hard. Extra rest and earlier bedtimes are common during the transition.

Your child might not want to talk about school. This is perfectly normal and does not mean anything is wrong. Children process experiences differently than adults. Rather than peppering them with questions, try sitting together quietly after school and letting them share on their own timeline.

Your child might test boundaries at home. When children experience a new environment with clear, consistent expectations, they sometimes push harder at home to see if the same structure applies. This is a sign of healthy processing. Stay calm, stay consistent, and know that it passes.

Your child might talk about “work.” In Montessori, we use the word “work” rather than “play” to describe what children do in the classroom. This is not because we are opposed to play, but because Montessori recognized that children’s self-chosen, purposeful activity deserves the dignity of being called what it is: meaningful work.

If anything concerns you, please reach out. We are here to support you through this transition, not just your child.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Email 6: Why Montessori Looks Different

Trigger: 7 days after first day

EMAIL | Day 7 of attendance

Subject: Why Montessori Looks Different (and Why That's Good)

Dear [Parent First Name],

By now, you may have questions about some of the things you have observed or heard about. Perhaps your child mentioned choosing their own work, or you noticed the classroom does not have a traditional teacher's desk at the front. Let us explain a few things that often surprise new families.

There are no grades, sticker charts, or reward systems. Montessori education is built on the understanding that children are naturally motivated to learn. External rewards, while well-intentioned, can actually diminish a child's intrinsic motivation. Instead, children experience the natural satisfaction of mastering a new skill or completing meaningful work.

The guide does not lecture. In a Montessori classroom, the guide gives brief, precise lessons to small groups or individual children and then steps back. The guide's primary role is to observe, to connect each child with the right challenge at the right time, and to protect the working environment.

Children are not separated by ability. In the mixed-age classroom, children work at their own level, not at a grade level. A child who is ready for more advanced work moves forward. A child who needs more time with a concept gets that time without stigma. There is no top or bottom of the class.

It might feel slow at first. Some children take weeks or even a couple of months to fully settle into the rhythm of the classroom. This is expected and healthy. The Montessori approach trusts that when children are given time, space, and the right environment, they will reveal their capabilities in their own time.

Trust the process. Your child's guide is watching closely and will keep you informed as your child finds their rhythm.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Email 7: Building Independence at Home

Trigger: 14 days after first day

EMAIL | Day 14 of attendance

Subject: Simple Ways to Bring Montessori Home

Dear [Parent First Name],

One of the most common questions we hear from new families is: “How can I support what is happening in the classroom at home?” The good news is that Montessori principles translate beautifully to home life, and you do not need special materials or training.

Create a place for everything. Children thrive when they know where things belong. Low hooks for coats, a designated shelf for shoes, accessible shelves for books and activities. When everything has a place, children can participate in maintaining their environment.

Invite participation in real work. Children are deeply satisfied by contributing to the real work of the household. Depending on your child’s age, this might include setting the table, washing vegetables, folding towels, watering plants, or preparing simple snacks. These are not chores — they are opportunities for your child to feel capable and connected.

Slow down and allow time. One of the hardest things for busy parents is allowing children the time to do things themselves. Buttoning a coat, pouring water, tying shoes — these take longer when a child does them independently, but each attempt builds coordination, concentration, and confidence.

Limit screen time and protect boredom. Montessori children develop deep concentration through sustained, self-directed activity. Excessive screen use can fragment attention. Try to protect unstructured time at home where your child can simply be — drawing, building, exploring outside, or even doing nothing at all.

You are already doing more than you think. Every time you pause and let your child try, you are reinforcing the same message they receive at school: I trust you, I believe in you, and I know you are capable.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Email 8: Understanding Your Child's Development

Trigger: 21 days after first day

EMAIL | Day 21 of attendance

Subject: What Your Child Is Really Learning Right Now

Dear [Parent First Name],

Three weeks in, your child is settling into the rhythm of the classroom. But what is actually happening beneath the surface?

Maria Montessori observed that children pass through sensitive periods, windows of intense interest and readiness for specific types of learning. These are not arbitrary — they are biologically driven and follow a universal pattern across cultures.

For children ages 0–3: Your child is in a period of incredible sensory and motor development. Everything they touch, taste, carry, pour, and stack is building neural pathways that form the foundation for all future learning. What looks like simple play is actually the most important work they will ever do.

For children ages 3–6: Your child is in the period of conscious absorption. They are building an understanding of order, language, mathematics, and their social world through hands-on, concrete experiences. The Montessori materials in the classroom are designed to isolate concepts so children can discover patterns independently.

For children ages 6–12: Your child is entering the period of intellectual exploration. They are asking big questions about the universe, about fairness, about how things work and why. The Montessori elementary curriculum responds with the Great Lessons — sweeping, inspiring narratives that place your child's learning in the context of cosmic and human history.

Every day your child spends in the classroom, they are building the internal architecture for a lifetime of learning. The work is happening, even when it is not immediately visible from the outside.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Email 9: Your First Month — A Reflection

Trigger: 30 days after first day

EMAIL | Day 30 of attendance

Subject: One Month In — How Far You've Come

Dear [Parent First Name],

One month ago, you walked your child into Willow Creek for the first time. Take a moment to appreciate how much has happened since then.

Your child has begun to find their place in a carefully prepared community. They are building relationships with their guide and their classmates. They are developing daily rhythms and routines. They are learning to make choices, to concentrate, and to take care of themselves and their environment.

And you, as a parent, have been on your own journey. You have navigated drop-offs, resisted the urge to ask too many questions at pickup, and begun to trust a process that may feel very different from what you expected.

A few things to reflect on:

What have you noticed changing in your child since starting school? What has surprised you most about the Montessori approach? What questions are you still carrying?

We would love to hear your reflections. Please feel free to reach out to your child's guide or to [Head of School Name] directly. We also encourage you to sign up for an in-classroom observation, which many parents find to be one of the most eye-opening experiences of their Montessori journey.

You are doing a wonderful job. Keep going.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Email 10: Becoming a Montessori Family

Trigger: 60 days after first day

EMAIL | Day 60 of attendance

Subject: You're Not Just Enrolled — You're Part of a Community

Dear [Parent First Name],

Two months ago, you were a new family. Today, you are part of the Willow Creek community. We want to invite you to deepen that connection.

Parent Education

Throughout the year, we offer parent education evenings, book discussions, and workshops on topics ranging from discipline and screen use to developmental milestones and Montessori philosophy. These events are one of the best ways to build understanding and connect with other families.

Classroom Observations

If you have not yet observed in your child's classroom, we strongly encourage it. Watching your child work in the prepared environment, seeing how the guide interacts, and witnessing the calm, focused energy of the classroom is something no email or article can replicate.

Community Involvement

Our school thrives because families contribute their time, skills, and presence. Whether it is helping with a classroom project, joining a committee, attending school events, or simply showing up with presence and partnership, your involvement matters.

Continued Learning

Your Montessori journey does not stop at the school door. We recommend exploring Montessori Navigator, a platform created by the Montessori Foundation that offers age-based guidance, practical tools, and a thoughtful approach to Montessori parenting. It is the same resource our school uses and trusts.

Thank you for choosing Willow Creek. Thank you for trusting the process. And thank you for being part of what makes this community extraordinary.

Warmly,

The Willow Creek Montessori Team

Recommended Resources by Phase

Each phase of onboarding is strengthened by pairing emails with educational content. Below are recommended articles, guides, and resources to share with families at each stage. Schools should customize these with their own content library and link to Montessori Navigator resources where applicable.

Phase 1: Welcome and Prepare

- What Is Montessori? A Parent's Guide (introductory overview)
- The Role of the Montessori Guide (how the teacher role differs from conventional)
- School Handbook or Family Agreement (your school's specific document)
- Montessori Navigator: School Decision Clarity tools (Montessori Navigator resource)

Phase 2: Settle and Understand

- Why Your Child Says They 'Worked' Today (explaining Montessori language)
- The First Six Weeks: What to Expect (normalizing the transition period)
- Understanding the Three-Year Cycle (why mixed ages and why staying matters)
- Montessori Navigator: Parenting Confidence tools (age-specific dashboards)

Phase 3: Deepen and Partner

- Bringing Montessori Home (practical implementation guide)
- Sensitive Periods of Development (understanding your child's inner timeline)
- Screens and Montessori: A Balanced Approach (a framework, not a lecture)
- Montessori Navigator: Home Implementation tools (environment guides, independence roadmaps)

School-Specific Touchpoints

Emails are only one part of onboarding. The most effective programs combine automated communication with personal, human connection. Below are the recommended personal touchpoints that should accompany the email sequence.

Personal Welcome Call

Within the first week of enrollment, the head of school or enrollment coordinator should make a personal phone call or send a brief video message to welcome the family. This is not a logistics call — it is a relationship-building call. The goal is to make the family feel seen, valued, and personally welcomed. Five minutes of genuine connection can set the tone for the entire enrollment.

Guide Introduction

Before or on the first day, the lead guide should send a brief, personal note to the family. This can be a handwritten card, a short email, or a brief video. The message should be warm, personal, and focused on the child: “I am looking forward to meeting [child name] and learning what excites them.”

In-Classroom Observation

Within the first three to four weeks, invite the family to observe in their child’s classroom. Provide a brief observation guide so parents know what to look for. Follow up with a conversation about what they saw. This is often the moment when philosophical understanding clicks for families.

30-Day Check-In

At the one-month mark, schedule a brief informal check-in with the family. This can be a quick phone call, an in-person conversation at pickup, or a scheduled meeting. Ask how they are feeling, what questions they have, and what has surprised them. Listen more than you talk.

90-Day Community Welcome

At the end of the onboarding period, formally acknowledge the family as a full member of the school community. This might be a mention at a school gathering, a small welcome gift, a note from the head of school, or an invitation to a special event. The key is to mark the transition from “new family” to “our family.”

A Note on Montessori Growth Suite Users

If your school uses Montessori Growth Suite, all ten emails can be imported as a pre-built automation workflow. Personal touchpoints (phone calls, observations, check-ins) can be added as task reminders within the workflow so nothing falls through the cracks. See the companion Montessori Growth Suite Integration Guide for step-by-step instructions.

Closing: The Prepared Environment for Families

Maria Montessori understood that the environment shapes the child. The prepared classroom, with its carefully chosen materials, its beauty, its order, and its intentional design, is not a backdrop for learning. It is the teacher.

The same principle applies to how we welcome families. When we prepare a thoughtful onboarding environment, we are not simply transferring information. We are shaping the relationship between home and school. We are building the trust and understanding that will sustain a family through the inevitable questions, doubts, and breakthroughs of their Montessori journey.

This playbook is your prepared environment for families. Use it thoughtfully. Adapt it to your school's voice, values, and community. And remember that the most powerful thing you can offer any new family is not information — it is the experience of being truly welcomed.

Montessori Navigator™

A Prepared Environment for Parents

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